

Scrolling through TikTok

Notes on the pleasures of 'passive' consumption

Introduction: Why TikTok?

- Short video app; available internationally since around 2017; 800 million active users.
- Negative and patronising reporting on the app; image of it being an ultimate time-wasting machine (e.g. Odell 2019).
- Case to understand discourses of the good life in relation to digital media use and addictive media design.

The TikTok For You Page

- Content feed sitting at the heart of the app; central site of communicative interaction (mediated by algorithm).
- Form of communication on For You Page strongly marked by mimetics (see Schellewald 2021 or Zulli and Zulli 2020).
- Videos not experienced as discrete texts but assemblage/flow of videos materialising a personalised 'structure of feeling' (Williams 1974, 1977).

Pleasures of passive consumption

- TikTok appealed to young adults in moments of anxiety, stress, pressure, tiredness, or boredom. That means, as a site of momentary escape.
- Decision for TikTok within polymedia environment (Madianou and Miller 2012) was almost always to avoid senses of pressure to interact and perform experienced on other platforms.
- For You Page described as something 'ready-to-hand'. Very easy to just scroll without having to think or do anything on the app itself.

Agency: algorithms and everyday life

- Two forms of user activity during 'passive consumption': attachment to algorithm and contextual integration.
- High awareness for algorithm. Perception of it as having scary but appealing accuracy (cf. 'intimacy of surveillance', Ruckenstein and Granroth 2020).
- Users concealing their own activity of 'scrolling' as passive, even though constitutive in shaping For You Page.

Agency: algorithms and everyday life

- Relationship with algorithm/For You Page continuous process of human-machine interactions (Suchman 2007; cf. also Siles and Meléndez-Moran 2021).
- Flow set by TikTok algorithm 'addictive'. Response through contextual integration of app to supplement established rhythms of everyday life.
- Agency mattered to young adults of study less as being able to control TikTok as such but their ability to meaningfully integrate it in their day.

Ethnographic and adaptive

- Importance of attending to agency of managing rhythms of mundane everyday life / worldly belonging through media use (cf. also Markham 2020 or Paasonen 2021).
- Crucial role of taking an ethnographic stance to understand multiple forms of agency at play in relation to human-machine interactions.

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